

The Velvet Touch

A Thief's Guide to Silk and Shadow

Madam Serafine, Mistress of the Velvet Court

Silkstrand, Year of the Falling Bridge

The coin you take is never the one that costs you. The one you leave behind—that is the debt that collects.

— *The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking.* —

Preface: On Rising from the Gutter

I was seven when I picked my first pocket. A merchant from Kahfagia, fat with spices and arrogance. He never felt my fingers slip his purse. I watched him laugh with his friends while I bought bread for a week.

They never caught me. Not because I was clever—I was not, not yet. Because I was *nothing*. A gutter rat, a ghost in the crowd, a face that blend into wet cobblestones. That is the first lesson: power is not in the blade or the coin. It is in being *forgotten*.

Twenty years later, I own three warehouses, two gambling dens, and a brothel that also launders secrets. The Watch Captain owes me his promotion. The Dye Syndicate pays me not to undercut their prices. And the Archivolt notaries keep a drawer full of my forged seals—they do not know which are real.

I am Madam Serafine. They call me the Velvet Touch because I never leave bruises.

This book is not for heroes. It is for those who understand that the world runs on whispers, debts, and the careful omission of the truth. I learned from the streets. I learned from Ikasha, who sleeps in shadow, and from Livaea, who dresses power in silk and smiles. I learned that a song can open a lock faster than any pick, and that a forged document is worth a thousand swords.

You want to be a thief? Good. But first, forget everything you think you know. The mark is not the victim. The mark is the one who believes they are safe.

The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking.

Madam Serafine
Silkstrand, under the Three-Queens Bridge
The ink is lamp-black and my blood. The mirror is clean.

— *The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking.* —

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Part I

The Philosophy of the Quiet Hand

Chapter 1

On Being Nothing

The first time you break into a counting-house, you will be afraid. Good. Fear keeps your fingers light and your ears open. The moment you feel safe, you are already caught.

A thief is not a warrior. We do not fight. We *slip*. Through a window left unlatched, through a crowd that parts without knowing, through a contract signed in too much haste. The world is full of gaps—the ninth step un-counted, the witness who looked away, the seal that was pressed a moment too soon.

1.1 The Three Principles of the Velvet Hand

1.1.1 The Coin That Is Not There

Never take what will be missed before dawn. A silver coin from a rich man's purse? He will curse his servants, forget by noon. A ledger page that proves his fraud? He will burn the city to find it.

Take what they do not know they have *until it is too late*.

1.1.2 The Witness Who Looks Away

Every crime is witnessed. The trick is not to be invisible—it is to be *unremarkable*. A servant carrying linens. A clerk with a stack of writs. A beggar sleeping in the archway. The guards see you. They just do not *notice*.

1.1.3 The Debt That Pays Twice

When you steal, you create a debt. Not yours—*theirs*. They owe you for the fear you planted, the reputation you damaged, the secret you now hold. A true thief does not take gold. Gold spends. A secret spends forever.

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Chapter 2

Thief Talents: The Velvet Ladder

The following talents are suited for those who walk the edge of law and shadow. They are not for brawlers or brutes. They are for the quiet, the cunning, and the patient.

2.1 2 XP Talents — Foundations

2.1.1 Light Fingers

Tags: Strike, AGI, Gambit

You have stolen a hundred things without being caught. Once per scene, when you attempt to lift a small object (purse, key, letter, seal) from a person or desk, treat your first Stealth or Subterfuge roll as Position +1.

No one notices until it is already in your sleeve.

2.1.2 The Unlocked Window

Tags: Move, AGI, Flow

You know how buildings breathe. When infiltrating a structure you have cased for at least an hour, ignore one security obstacle (locked door, patrolled corridor, guard dog) per session. Describe how you already prepared for it.

2.1.3 Silk Palms

Tags: Influence, FAT

When you bribe or gift a minor official, you gain a temporary String: *Bought Silence*. Once, you may activate this String to reduce DV by 1 on a Petition or Broker action involving that official. The String is consumed afterward.

2.2 3–4 XP Talents — The Working Knife

2.2.1 Always Another Exit

Tags: Move, SPT, Gambit

When you are cornered or a heist goes wrong, you may declare you prepared an escape route earlier. Describe it plausibly (rope out a window, bribed a guard, secret door). The GM may impose a cost—a dropped item, a witness, a future debt—but you *get out*.

Once per session.

2.2.2 The Forger’s Eye

Tags: Craft, WIT, Clock

You can copy any handwriting, seal, or signature with uncanny accuracy. When you attempt to forge a document, roll Wits + Craft (DV 3 for simple, 4–5 for complex). On a hit, create a **Forged Diamond** (see Chapter 2). On a partial, the forgery holds for one scene; thereafter it may be detected.

2.2.3 Crowd Veil

Tags: Observe, MIG, Support

You vanish into crowds. When in a populated area (market, festival, dock), you may roll Stealth vs. DV 3 to become *Hidden in plain sight*. Pursuers suffer -1 die to find you until you act conspicuously.

2.3 5 XP Talents — Signature Moves

2.3.1 The Velvet Glove

Tags: Influence, Strike, Combo

You have cultivated a network of informants, fence contacts, and corrupted clerks. Once per session, you may declare that a minor NPC (a servant, a dockworker, a scribe) owes you a favor. They provide a specific service: unlock a door, delay a patrol, deliver a message. The GM may dictate a cost (the NPC will later need help, or their favor expires after use).

2.3.2 Master of Misdirection

Tags: Influence, Gambit, SB

When you are discovered during a crime, you may spend 1 Boon to redirect suspicion to another person or faction. Roll Deception vs. DV 4. On a hit, the heat shifts; on a miss, you gain Exposure +1 and the target becomes hostile.

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2.4 6 XP Talent — The Quiet Catastrophe

2.4.1 The Ghost Did It

Tags: Strike, Clock, Overload

Once per arc, you may commit a crime that is never solved—not because you are perfect, but because the evidence points nowhere. After a successful heist, you may declare that no traceable evidence remains. The GM cannot use Social SB to retroactively implicate you from that scene. Cost: You must accept a permanent *Reputation: Whispers* tag; some will always suspect you, even without proof.

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Chapter 3

Rogue Builds for the Silkstrand Night

3.1 The Cat Burglar

Core Talents: Light Fingers, The Unlocked Window, Always Another Exit. **Style:** High, vertical, through windows and rooftops. **Patron:** Ikasha.

3.2 The Confidence Artist

Core Talents: Silk Palms, The Forger's Eye, Velvet Glove. **Style:** Social infiltration, false identities, forged documents. **Patron:** Livaea.

3.3 The Saboteur

Core Talents: Crowd Veil, Master of Misdirection, The Ghost Did It. **Style:** Disruption, frame-ups, political chaos. **Patron:** Malachai (rare) or Aveh.

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Part II

The Forger's Art

Chapter 4

The Weight of Paper

In Silkstrand, the right seal is worth more than a ship. A stamped manifest can move contraband past the harbor master. A notary's ribbon can turn stolen goods into legitimate auction lots. A letter of credit can buy a warehouse with no coin changing hands.

Forgery is not crime. It is *reality editing*.

4.1 The Forging Mini-Game

To forge a document, you need three things:

1. **Knowledge** of what the genuine document looks like—its paper, ink, seal, and language.
2. **A Sample** — at least one authentic example to copy, or a witness who can describe it in detail.
3. **A Workshop** — a quiet place with the right tools: quills, inks, sealing wax, a press, and a steady hand.

4.1.1 The Four Steps of Forgery

Step 1: Research (Wits + Investigation, DV 2–4) Learn the document's specifics. On a hit, gain +1 die to the Craft roll. On a miss, you miss a crucial detail—the forgery will be detectable.

Step 2: Materials (Wits + Streetwise, DV 3) Source matching paper, ink, and seal. On a hit, the materials are adequate. On a partial, they are close but flawed (the forgery holds for one scene, then degrades). On a miss, you must substitute inferior materials—the forgery starts with a *Suspicious* tag.

Step 3: The Craft (Wits + Craft, DV 3 for simple (receipt, note), 4 for standard (manifest, writ), 5 for complex (royal charter, embassy seal)) Roll to create the forged document. On a hit, you produce a **Forged Diamond**. On a partial, produce a **Fragile Diamond**—it works once, then crumbles (detected). On a miss, the forgery is worthless; you may salvage materials for another attempt, but the GM gains 1 SB.

Step 4: Presentation (Presence + Deception vs. DV of the examiner) When you present the forgery, roll against the target's Insight or relevant skill. On a hit, the document is accepted. On a partial, they are suspicious—offer concession (bribe, favor, or they keep the document for “verification”). On a miss, they detect the forgery; your Exposure ticks +1 and the document is seized.

4.1.2 Forged Diamond Types

- **Cargo Manifest** – Legal immunity for smuggling. Lasts one voyage.
- **Notarial Seal** – Validates a contract or deed. Lasts one arbitration.
- **Letter of Credit** – Withdraw funds from a named merchant house. One use.
- **Writ of Passage** – Skip tolls and inspections on a named road or river. One journey.
- **Identity Papers** – Assume a false identity for one scene.
- **Pardon** – Commutes a minor crime. Requires a public reading.

4.1.3 Failure and Consequences

When a forgery is detected, the GM may choose one:

- **Exposure** – Your reputation among officials drops. Tick Exposure [4] for the city or faction.
- **Debt** – The examiner does not report you—instead, they demand a favor.
- **Bounty** – A warrant is quietly issued. A rival thief may claim it.
- **Counterfeit Trail** – Your forged seal is used by someone else later, framing you.

Chapter 5

Fence and Laundry

Once you have stolen goods, you need to sell them. The art of laundering is not hiding—it is *recontextualizing*.

5.0.1 Laundering Clocks

To launder a stolen item or forged Diamond, start a **Laundry Clock** [4] (small items) or [6] (major items). Each downtime scene, you may work one tick by:

- Bribing a fence (spend 1 Favor or 1 Boon)
- Moving goods through a neutral market (risk Exposure +1)
- Using a genuine paper trail (requires a Forged Diamond)

When the clock fills, the item is clean—it can be sold at full value or used without suspicion.

If you fail to complete the clock within three sessions, the item becomes *Hot*. Selling it then risks Exposure +2 and a visit from the original owner’s agents.

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Part III

The Cantor's Cadence

Chapter 6

The Voice That Opens Doors

Singing is not for taverns alone. A well-timed tune can calm a crowd, distract a guard, or deliver a secret message in plain hearing. The Cantor's path is the thief's second skin—especially when the singer cares more for the lock than the lyric.

6.1 The Rogue Cantor: Song as Setup

Most Cantors perform for applause. A rogue Cantor performs for *opportunity*. While the audience watches the singer, their pockets are already empty.

6.1.1 Performance as Distraction

When you sing or play in a public space, roll Presence + Performance against a DV set by crowd size (2 for small, 4 for large). On a hit, you create an **Engrossed Audience** tag. For the duration of your song, any ally attempting Stealth or Subterfuge in the same area gains +1 die.

On a partial, the crowd is attentive but some watch the exits—Stealth rolls are unchanged, but allies gain +1 Position to social rolls.

6.1.2 The Encore Gambit

Once per session, after a successful performance, you may declare an *Encore*. The crowd demands more. This extends your distraction for an additional scene, but the GM gains 1 SB (the guards are curious now).

6.2 Corrupted Cantors: The Cult of the Velvet Note

Not all Cantors walk the road alone. Some find patrons in the shadows—beings who grant power in exchange for a different kind of song.

6.2.1 Ikasha's Whisper (Shadow Cantor)

Ikasha speaks in the space between notes. Followers learn to sing in frequencies that do not carry, to hum a lullaby that makes guards sleep, to whistle a tune that unlocks spirit-locks.

Corruption: Your voice develops a second timber—a whisper that follows your sung words. Strangers shiver when you speak. Allies sometimes hear you when you are not there.

Rites:

- *Cradle Song* (Low) – Lull a single target (Resist DV 3). Costs 1 Fatigue.
- *Lockpick’s Refrain* (Standard) – Unlock one mundane or warded lock by humming its true pitch. Costs 1 Obligation.

6.2.2 Livaea’s Velvet Hook (Social Cantor)

Livaea teaches that every song is a seduction. Her Cantors do not charm—they *bind*. A promise sung in her name is a thread that tightens with every breath.

Corruption: Your eyes take on a reflective quality. In dim light, others see their own desires mirrored there.

Rites:

- *Golden Tongue* (Low) – Gain +2 dice to Sway for one social exchange. Costs 1 Fatigue; after use, the target feels a mild attraction or obligation.
- *The Unrefusable Offer* (Standard) – Sing a bargain. Target must accept or suffer -2 dice to all rolls until they do. Costs 2 Obligation.

6.2.3 Malachai’s False Note (Desperate Cantor)

Malachai answers when the thief has nothing left to lose. Her Cantors sing of easy scores, of curses as blessings, of the coin that spends itself. The price is always a piece of the singer’s soul.

Corruption: Your voice cracks on certain notes. Those who hear you feel a brief, inexplicable hunger.

Rites:

- *The Lucky Pick* (Low) – Reroll a failed Stealth or Subterfuge roll. Costs 1 Fatigue and 1 Corruption tick.
- *Blood Price* (Standard) – Sing a curse on a rival. They suffer -1 die on their next heist. Costs 2 Fatigue and marks a *Debt Clock* [4] that Malachai will collect.

Chapter 7

Building a Rogue Cantor

7.1 The Whisper (Shadow Focus)

Talents: Ikasha's rites, Stealth, Performance. Role: Infiltrator, messenger, spy. Progression: Low rites → Crowd Veil → Ikasha's Mark.

7.2 The Siren (Social Focus)

Talents: Livaea's rites, Sway, Silk Palms. Role: Confidence artist, blackmailer, courtesan-spy. Progression: Golden Tongue → Velvet Glove → The Unrefusable Offer.

7.3 The Cornered Rat (Desperate Focus)

Talents: Malachai's rites, Always Another Exit, Master of Misdirection. Role: Saboteur, desperate fugitive, self-destructive genius. Progression: Lucky Pick → Blood Price → The Ghost Did It.

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Part IV

Patrons of the Underworld

Chapter 8

Ikasha – She Who Sleeps in Shadow

8.1 Lore

Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. She does not command. She *sleeps*. But in her dreams, she whispers possibilities.

Thieves who follow Ikasha learn to move unseen, to speak unremembered, to become shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

8.2 Advantages for Rogues

- **Soft Witness** – Your first Stealth roll each scene is Position +1.
- **Shadow Meld** – Once per session, step into a shadow and emerge from another within Near range.
- **The Unobserved** – When you are Hidden, Social SB cannot be used to frame you (unless you act first).

8.3 Drawbacks

- **The Witness Debt** – Every time you use Ikasha's power, you mark a *Witness Clock* [4]. When it fills, a raven appears to watch your next crime. If you fail that roll, the raven reports to a rival.
- **Light Sensitivity** – In bright conditions (direct sun, magical illumination), your Stealth rolls suffer -1 die.

8.4 Rites for the Rogue Cantor

- *The Unlatched Window* (Low) – Gain +2 dice to open one lock or window silently.
- *Raven Courier* (Standard) – Send a whispered message up to a mile away via a spectral raven.
- *Threshold of Sleep* (High) – Walk through a locked door as if it were mist. Costs 2 Fatigue and marks Obligation.

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Chapter 9

Livaea – The Crimson Courtier

9.1 Lore

Livaea is the whisper behind the curtain, the smile that sells secrets, the velvet hand that closes a cage. She rules through allure, performance, and the hunger for connection.

Thieves who follow Livaea do not steal coins—they steal *trust*. A stolen kiss, a forged letter, a lover's secret sold to the highest bidder.

9.2 Advantages for Rogues

- **Courtly Graces** – You gain +1 die to Sway and Performance in any refined setting.
- **The Velvet Glove** – Once per session, you may declare a minor NPC is your secret admirer or blackmail victim. They will help you once.
- **Unreadable Mask** – You may spend 1 Boon to ignore one Social SB spend against you (the scandal simply fails to stick).

9.3 Drawbacks

- **The Jealous Court** – When you use Livaea's power publicly, mark a *Rival Clock* [4]. When it fills, a former paramour or jilted client becomes a recurring enemy.
- **Addicted to Adoration** – If you go more than a session without a notable social triumph, you suffer -1 die to all social rolls until you perform a grand gesture.

9.4 Rites for the Rogue Cantor

- *Silk Whisper* (Low) – Send a telepathic sentence to a willing target within sight.
- *The Shared Cup* (Standard) – Share a drink with a target; they cannot lie to you for the next hour.
- *The Crimson Masquerade* (High) – Assume the appearance of any person you have touched for one scene. Costs 2 Fatigue.

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Chapter 10

Aveh – The Rider Behind the Storm (For Fugitives)

10.1 Lore

Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon's edge. She offers freedom at the cost of belonging. Thieves who need to vanish—from a bad debt, a murder charge, a betrayed partner—pray to Aveh.

10.2 Advantages

- **The Escape Clause** – Once per session, you may declare an escape route that was not there before. The GM must accept it, but may impose a cost (you left something behind).
- **Forgotten Face** – Witnesses have -2 dice to recall your description.

10.3 Drawbacks

- **The Erased Name** – Each time you use Aveh's power, you lose a minor personal connection (a contact forgets you, a safe house is no longer safe).
- **No Home** – You cannot stay in one city for more than a season without attracting the Rider's attention.

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Chapter 11

Malachai – The Chained Angel (For the Desperate)

See the expansion *Malachai, the Chained Angel*. For thieves, she offers cursed luck—a die that always rolls high, but at the cost of a slow corruption. Use sparingly; Malachai is a patron for characters who are already falling.

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Chapter 12

Choosing Your Patron

Patron	Best for	Worst for
Ikasha	Silent infiltration, ghost thieves	Social scenes, bright areas
Livaea	Con artists, spies, courtesans	Those who hate attention
Aveh	Fugitives, escape artists	Anyone who wants roots
Malachai	Desperate gamblers, cursed builds	Long-term campaigns

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Part V

Appendices

Appendix A

Sample Schemes

A.0.1 The False Heir

Forge a letter of introduction from a distant relative. Infiltrate a noble house. Steal the heirloom. Disappear before the real relative arrives. **Clocks:** Forgery [6], Infiltration [4], Escape [4].

A.0.2 The Ghost Cargo

Steal a shipment of silk. Replace it with crates of sand. Sell the silk in another port using forged manifests. The merchant spends months investigating “thieves” who never existed. **Clocks:** Heist [6], Laundry [6], Investigation [8] (enemy).

A.0.3 The Rival’s Downfall

Plant forged evidence of embezzlement in a rival thief’s safehouse. Tip off the Watch. Claim their territory when they are arrested. **Clocks:** Forgery [4], Infiltration [4], Frame Job [6], Territory Grab [4].

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Appendix B

NPC Profiles

B.0.1 The Watch Captain (Corrupt)

Name: Captain Vellis. **Tier:** III. **Strings:** Patrol routes, jail keys, informant network. **Leverage:** He owes you for not exposing his affair. **Price:** 1 Favor = one night of ignored patrols.

B.0.2 The Fence

Name: Old Kes. **Tier:** II. **Strings:** Underground market, smuggler boats, counterfeit coin. **Price:** 50% of the value, no questions. For an extra 10%, he will also launder the goods (start Laundry Clock at +1).

B.0.3 The Rival Thief

Name: “Quick” Lena. **Tier:** III. **Strings:** A network of urchin spies, a stolen set of master keys, a grudge against you. **Weakness:** She cannot resist a taunt. Use Deception to draw her into a trap.

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Appendix C

The Velvet Court's Oath

When you join my organization, you speak this oath. It is not binding by law. It is binding by *reputation*. Break it, and no fence in Silkstrand will touch you.

I take the coin that is not wanted. I leave no witness that remembers. I pay my debts in silence or in blood. I do not betray the velvet hand. So sworn, under the Three-Queens Bridge, at the hour when lanterns gutter.

— *The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking.* —

Colophon

This book was written in a back room of the Velvet Court, on paper that had once been a customs manifest. The ink is lamp-black cut with the ash of a burned ledger. The binding is silk thread, dyed red with madder root and a single drop of my own blood—for luck.

The lantern gutters. The night is young. There is a mark waiting at the Counting House, and he does not yet know that his fortune is already spent.

*Madam Serafine
Silkstrand, under the Three-Queens Bridge
The ink is fresh. The coin is warm.*